

The Subcommittee on Plant Health Diagnostics (SPHD) is a subcommittee of the Plant Health Committee (PHC). It leads plant pest diagnostics policy, standards and coordination for Australia.

## Purpose

SPHD oversees national functions, enablers, and drivers for plant pest diagnostics and works to:

- improve the quality and reliability of plant pest diagnostics
- enhance our capacity and capability to diagnose plant pests.

## Priorities

SPHD activities are guided by its high-level priorities to strengthen the national diagnostic system, build diagnostic capacity and capability and ensure national quality and consistency—with activity focused on diagnostics for our [National Priority Plant Pest \(NPPP\)](#).

### Strengthen national diagnostic system

To further this priority, SPHD:

- implements the [National Plant Biosecurity Diagnostic Strategy](#) as part of broader [National Plant Biosecurity Strategy](#).
- helps implement the National Plant Pest Reference Collections Strategy
- supports implementation of relevant schedules in the Intergovernmental Agreement on Biosecurity (IGAB)
- develops guidelines for emerging diagnostic technologies
- develops national plant health diagnostic policies and processes.

### Build diagnostic capacity and capability

SPHD builds capacity and capability for plant pest identification through National Plant Biosecurity Diagnostic Network programs that include:

- residential training
- skills workshops
- annual diagnosticians workshops.

### Ensure national quality and consistency

SPHD:

- develops and improves [National Diagnostic Protocols](#)
- standardises reference materials
- delivers laboratory accreditation and proficiency testing

- oversees the delivery of the National Plant Health Proficiency Testing Program (NPHPTP)
- implements recommendations from NPHPTP reviews.

## Working groups

The SPHD has formed working groups to deliver its priorities:

- Diagnostic Protocols Working Group
- Network Implementation Working Group
- Reference Collections Implementation Plan Working Group
- High Throughput Sequencing Working Group
- Domestic Movement Working Group.

## Membership and meetings

Members include representatives from the Australian, state and territory governments. They are nominated based on their expertise. Members provide technical advice to the PHC on plant health diagnostic matters.

The Chair position is rotated among members.

Observers may come from government agencies, statutory authorities, or government-industry co-funded companies. Observers don't have voting rights.

Observers currently include representatives from:

- Biosecurity New Zealand, Ministry for Primary Industries
- CSIRO
- Plant Health Australia.

The SPHD meet face to face twice a year. The Australian Government provides secretariat support.

## Communiqués

- [SPHD Communiqué 40 \(DOCX 1.0 MB\)](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 39 \(DOCX 986 KB\)](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 35 \(DOCX 764 KB\)](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 34](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 33](#)

Note: SPHD did not release a communiqué for meetings 27 to 32

- [SPHD Communiqué 26](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 25](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 24](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 23](#)
- [SPHD Communiqué 22](#)

- [SPHD Communiqué 21](#)
- [SPHDS\\* Communiqué 20](#)
- [SPHDS\\* Communiqué 19](#)
- [SPHDS\\* Communiqué 18](#)
- [SPHDS\\* Communiqué 17](#)

\*SPHD's former name was the Subcommittee on Plant Health Diagnostic Standards.

If you have difficulty accessing these files, [contact us](#) for help.

## See more

Learn more about diagnostic strategies and initiatives linked to SPHD's work.

## Contact us

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